



A Student's Guide on How to Find Off-Campus Housing

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Congratulations, you're heading to college. This should be an exciting time in your life, and to make your transition easier, we've compiled a guide on how to look for off-campus housing.

While on-campus housing offers convenience and a built-in community, many students opt for [off-campus living](#) for reasons like greater independence, more diverse living environments, potentially lower costs, or the ability to choose roommates. This Redfin student resource will walk you through essential steps and considerations to help you find suitable off-campus housing.

>> If you're an international student exploring off-campus housing, check out Redfin's [How to Rent an Apartment as an International Student](#) guide for more information.

>> Understand [The Fair Housing Act](#) before getting started.

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Evaluate various neighborhoods

Before you even start looking at specific listings, take the time to research different neighborhoods around your campus. Consider factors such as:

- **Proximity to campus:** How important is it to be within walking or biking distance? Explore Redfin's [Walk Score](#) to gain a better understanding of a neighborhood's walkability.
- **Transportation options:** Are there public transit routes available if you don't have a car? Utilize your phone's map application to get a better idea of what your daily commute could look like from your residence to university.
- **Amenities:** What services are nearby (grocery stores, pharmacies, laundromats, restaurants)? If you don't own a car, be sure to explore how accessible these essential places are via public transportation.
- **Noise levels:** Are you looking for a quiet study environment or a more lively area? For those living in a more bustling area, you may encounter noise from neighbors, delivery trucks, or pedestrians and traffic.

Determine your budget

This is perhaps the most crucial step. Beyond just rent, factor in all potential monthly expenses:

- **Utilities:** Some apartments include the cost of utilities in their total monthly rent. Ask whether utilities are included to make sure you stay within your planned rent budget.
- **Internet connection:** You'll most likely need to access your coursework from home, so don't forget to add internet costs to your budget.
- **Transportation:** Gas, public transit passes, or parking permits.
- **Food:** Your grocery and dining-out budget.
- **Personal expenses:** Laundry, toiletries, and entertainment.

Create a realistic budget and stick to it. Typically, landlords check that a [renter's income](#) is 3x the amount of rent. However, if your income provided does not meet the landlord's income requirement, a [co-signer](#) can help offer students the financial security that they need for a lease. ^

Example: If a rental is \$2,000 per month, your verifiable income should be equal to or greater than \$6,000.

**Some apartments include the cost of utilities in total monthly rent payments. Ask whether utilities are included to make sure you stay within your planned budget.*

>> Learn more about [budgeting for rent](#)

Beware of fake listings

The internet is a powerful tool for finding housing, but it's also ripe for scams. Be cautious of:

- **Prices that seem too good to be true:** Unusually low rent for a prime location is a red flag.
- **Landlords who are out of the country and can't show the property:** This is a common tactic.
- **Requests for money before you've seen the property or signed a lease:** Never send money via wire transfer or gift cards.
- **Listings with vague descriptions or poor-quality photos:** This isn't always a sign of a scam; however, if you're ever uncertain, request more photos and information.

Always verify the listing and, if possible, safely visit the property in person.

Where to look for off-campus housing

Your university is a great place to start your off-campus housing search. Many schools have resource pages for international students moving to the U.S. to help with documents, roommate searches, and housing searches.

Once you're ready to look for listings, use a national rental website like [Redfin](#), [ApartmentGuide](#), or [Rent.com](#). Local social media pages and neighborhood message boards can also be a good source of local listings, but be extra careful of [rental scams](#).

Understand broker fees



In some areas, especially urban centers, you might encounter real estate brokers who help connect tenants with available properties. If you use a broker, or [rental agent](#), be prepared for:

- **Broker fees:** These are typically a percentage of the annual rent or a flat fee, often paid by the tenant (not the renter).
- **One-time payment:** Broker fees are usually a one-time charge, distinct from security deposits or first/last month's rent.

Always clarify any broker fees upfront and get them in writing before engaging their services.

Inspect the property condition

- **Structural issues:** Cracks in walls, ceiling stains, signs of water damage.
- **Working appliances:** Test all kitchen appliances, laundry machines, and heating/cooling systems.
- **Plumbing:** Flush toilets, run faucets, and check for leaks.
- **Electrical outlets and lighting:** Ensure all are functional.
- **Pest control:** Look for signs of pests like rodents or insects.

Take photos or videos of any existing damage before you move in to avoid being charged for it later.

Watch out for hidden fees

Some landlords or property management companies may include additional fees not immediately obvious in the advertised rent. Ask about:

- **Application fees:** For background and credit checks.
- **Pet fees/deposits:** If you have pets.
- **Parking fees:** For dedicated parking spots.
- **Amenity fees:** For access to gyms, pools, or common areas.
- **Early termination fees:** If you need to break the lease.

These fees are typically spelled out in your lease, however, always request a full breakdown of all potential costs before committing.



Read and understand the lease agreement

Your [lease agreement](#) is a legally binding document. **Do not sign it until you have read and understood every single clause.** Pay close attention to:

- **Lease term:** The start and end dates of your tenancy.
- **Rent amount and due date:** And any late fees.
- **Renewal terms:** How to renew or terminate the lease.
- **Maintenance responsibilities:** Who is responsible for repairs (landlord vs. tenant)?
- **Pet policy:** If applicable.
- **Subletting policy:** Can you sublet if you leave for a semester?
- **Rules and regulations:** Noise policies, guest policies, etc.

If anything is unclear, ask the landlord or property manager for clarification. Consider having a trusted adult or legal aid service review it.

Manage your security deposit

A [security deposit](#) is money held by the landlord to cover potential damages beyond normal wear and tear or unpaid rent.

- **Know the amount:** This is usually one to two months' rent.
- **Understand conditions for return:** The lease should outline what qualifies for deductions.
- **Perform a move-in inspection:** As mentioned earlier, document the property's condition before moving in.
- **Perform a move-out inspection:** When you leave, do a final walkthrough with the landlord, if possible, to agree on any damages.
- **Know the timeline for return:** Landlords typically have a set period (e.g., 30 days) to return your deposit, less any justified deductions, after you move out.

Keep detailed records of all communications and payments related to your security deposit.

Now you're prepared to explore off-campus housing:



Finding off-campus housing requires careful planning and diligence. By evaluating neighborhoods, setting a realistic budget, being wary of scams, understanding all fees, thoroughly inspecting properties, and meticulously reading your lease, you can navigate the process successfully and find a comfortable and affordable place to call home during your academic journey.

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